of interest, whether at the USI or IPCS or ORF, and meeting our own scholars (I used to interact most often with Dr Madhu Bhalla and Dr Shrikant Kondapalli, both China experts) to build a comprehensive picture of our assigned countries. Through my research, I deduced that China had downscaled the number of group armies (GA) within the People's Liberation Army (PLA) from twenty-one to nineteen, which created some ripples in the MO and MI Directorates. Following up on this, I also wrote a paper on the PLA's War Zone Concept (WZC), putting a different spin on how the battle is likely to unfold at the operational and tactical level. Yet another paper was on force structuring, on why and how, instead of raising additional Divisions (a proposal already in the pipeline) we should instead concentrate on acquiring more force multipliers and raising organizations such as Aviation Brigades, rather than manpower-heavy, conventional Divisions. When I presented this paper in the MO operations room, it was met with stunned silence, with someone quite senior in the audience remarking, 'Son, it is a very thought-provoking presentation, but we are well on the way of getting government sanction for the raising of two new Divisions, so please don't rock the boat', or words to that effect.

One day in late 2005, I had gone to attend a seminar somewhere and reached the office shortly before the lunch break. As soon as I reached, Iqroop told me that my name was being considered for a foreign posting and that I should ring up the MS Branch forthwith, even giving me the number of the officer I was to contact. I thought he was pulling my leg, as I had never been called for an interview before. We had our lunch discussing the seminar I had just attended and went back to work. When Iqroop saw that I wasn't reacting, he came over to my desk, rang up the officer and shoved the phone into my hand. It turned out to be true. I was required to give my consent,

Copyright © Penguin Random House India
Not for circulation